



Partly sunny 69/51 • Tomorrow: Partly sunny 65/48 **B18**

Democracy Dies in Darkness

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MAJID SAEDI/GETTY IMAGES

People shop on Thursday in Tehran in preparation for Nowruz, the Persian New Year. The holiday falls this year three weeks into war.

U.S., Israeli objectives diverge as conflict deepens

BY JOHN HUDSON,
WARREN P. STROBEL
AND STEVE HENDRIX

When the United States and Israel initiated the war against Iran last month, their messages were perfectly in sync on the sweeping goal of regime change.

President Donald Trump told Iranians to seize their “only chance” for generations to “take over your government,” and Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu implored them to “cast off the yoke of this murderous regime.”

But nearly three weeks into the conflict, the war aims are diverging between a U.S. president who saw the historic opportunity of a quick military victory with only modest economic pain and an Israeli leader with grander visions of toppling a regime he's sought to vanquish for 40 years, said multiple U.S., Israeli and

Israel's strike on Iranian gas field renews tensions between the allies

Middle East officials and lawmakers familiar with the matter. Trump's latest outburst against Israel's attacks on Iran's huge South Pars gas field on Wednesday laid bare the tensions between the two allies and the inconsistency of the president's approach to the conflict.

Trump said Israel had “violently lashed out” at Iran and distanced himself from the assault on the world's largest natural gas deposit, which Iran shares with Qatar, a close U.S. ally and host of Washington's biggest military base in the Gulf.

“The United States knew nothing about this particular attack,

and the country of Qatar was in no way, shape, or form, involved with it,” Trump said on Truth Social.

But multiple officials directly contradicted that claim in conversations with The Washington Post, saying that while the U.S. was not involved in the strike, the Israelis informed Washington about the attack in advance.

The incident, which drove energy prices higher and prompted retaliatory Iranian missile fire at Qatar's main gas facility and Saudi Arabia's capital, was indicative of Trump's vacillation as he's tried to manage an unpopular war that has killed 13 Americans to date.

Trump has marveled at the devastation the military campaign has wrought on Iran's regime while recoiling at the catastrophic economic impacts rippling across the globe, said U.S. officials, who like others spoke on the condition of anonymity to

discuss the president's thinking. Netanyahu's months-long campaign to convince Trump to attack Iran and Secretary of State Marco Rubio's off-the-cuff disclosure that Israel's determination to strike compelled U.S. officials to act, infuriated Trump's “America First” supporters, who questioned a foreign power's role in bringing the U.S. to war.

The administration tried to reset the narrative that the war was Trump's decision alone but that message was undercut by this week's resignation of the president's top counterterrorism official, Joe Kent, who wrote in his resignation letter that the U.S. was dragged into another Middle East war “due to pressure from Israel and its powerful American lobby.”

SEE ISRAEL ON A14

Global impact: The U.S.-led war is hitting other countries harder. **A12**

Oil prices soar as Iran strikes energy facilities

COST PER BARREL PASSES \$119 AMID ATTACKS

Leaders around the globe call for war's de-escalation

This article is by Rachel Chason, Evan Halper, Victoria Crow, Siham Shamalakh and Tara Copp

DUBAI — Iran's escalating strikes on energy infrastructure across the Persian Gulf are stoking fears of a full-blown energy crisis, sending already high oil and gas prices surging and widening the scope of a war that has spilled across the region and upended the global economy.

After an Israeli strike Wednesday on Iran's portion of the South Pars gas field, which it shares with Qatar, Iran retaliated with attacks that caused “extensive damage” at Qatar's Ras Laffan Industrial City, the world's largest liquefied natural gas facility, officials said. The attacks sent the global oil benchmark soaring and prompted a scramble in

Washington. President Donald Trump threatened “to blow up the entirety” of Iran's South Pars gas holdings if Iran attacked Qatar again, and his treasury secretary said the United States would consider lifting sanctions on millions of barrels of Iranian oil.

“Energy warfare has been utilized from day one” of the conflict, said Anna Jacobs, a nonresident fellow at the Arab Gulf States Institute in Washington, to the greatest detriment of countries that rely on the Strait of Hormuz. Iranian attacks have mostly closed the narrow channel, a choke point for one-fifth of the world's oil supply, for weeks.

The Iran war is “in an escalation phase right now ... it is a nightmare scenario,” she said. SEE IRAN ON A13

Vance's support for war could cost him politically

BY NATALIE ALLISON
AND JOHN HUDSON

Vice President JD Vance is projecting loyalty to Donald Trump as the president leads the United States into the type of war the Iraq veteran didn't want — and as the new conflict complicates Vance's political future.

Vance allies have played down the impact the operation in Iran could have on his presidential ambitions, insisting that a mission involving the U.S. military only for a matter of weeks won't stay in voters' memories. People close to the vice president have also conceded to The Washington Post, however, that a months-long conflict will pose a problem for whoever is the next Republican nominee. The people spoke on the condition of anonymity to

comment on private discussions.

The war has put Vance in an increasingly difficult bind. Once a stalwart critic of America's costly military interventions overseas, the 41-year-old Marine veteran has found himself defending the president's growing appetite for military action while managing the fallout in a coalition that includes ardent war skeptics. He told The Post last month he still considers himself a “skeptic of foreign military interventions.”

The trickiness of his situation was highlighted this week with the resignation of Joe Kent, a senior White House official who quit over the war and publicly criticized Trump. During a private meeting, Vance tried to persuade Kent to not make his departure a public feud. It didn't work. SEE VANCE ON A9

American cities reckon with Chavez's legacy after report

Dozens of schools bear the name of labor activist accused of sexual assault

BY MOLLY HENNESSY-FISKE

Hours after she learned that César Chavez, the iconic Latino farm labor activist, had been accused of sexually assaulting girls in the movement he led, Austin city council member Vanessa Fuentes began hearing from constituents demanding the city rename César Chavez Street.

“So many native Austinites have photos with César Chavez and memories of interacting with him,” said Fuentes, the only Latina on the city council. “I've already received five emails from residents demanding that we rename it as soon as possible.”

The New York Times reported Wednesday that Chavez, who died in 1993, groomed and sexually abused young girls whose parents worked in the movement during the 1970s. The activist Dolores Huerta, who co-founded the National Farm Workers Association

with Chavez, also told the Times that Chavez sexually assaulted her when she was an adult.

In a statement, Huerta, who is 95, said she is speaking out because of the new report. She condemned his actions but emphasized that the farmworker movement, which spawned the still-powerful United Farm Workers of America, is bigger than one person.

“We must continue to engage and support our community, which needs advocacy and activism now more than ever,” she said.

The revelations about Chavez drew immediate calls to rename buildings, schools, streets and other memorials dedicated to him nationwide.

“I'm in mourning. It's like losing a dear friend that you thought was almost like a saint,” said Alicia Perez-Hodge, co-founder of the Hispanic Advocates Business Leaders of Austin and a district director for the League of United Latin American Citizens. “It's such a betrayal.”

Born in Yuma, Arizona, Chavez grew up in a Mexican American family that traveled around California picking lettuce, grapes, SEE CHAVEZ ON A7

Heads or Trump? The call is partly made.



U.S. TREASURY

Proposed designs for a \$1 coin featuring President Donald Trump. The plan calls for a 24-karat gold coin to be minted.

The president's chosen panel votes to put his image on U.S. currency

BY DAN DIAMOND

A federal arts commission on Thursday voted to approve a commemorative U.S. gold coin featuring Donald Trump, the administration's latest effort to celebrate the president, even as Democrats and members of another federal committee say the idea is deeply inappropriate and potentially illegal.

The proposal calls for a 24-karat gold coin depicting Trump leaning on a desk with clenched fists, based on a photograph taken by his chief White House photographer and now displayed in the Smithsonian's National Portrait Gallery. Such gold coins from the U.S. Mint typically sell for several thousand dollars. A Mint official told the panel that Trump had personally approved the design.

Members of the Commission of Fine Arts — composed entirely of Trump appointees, including a 26-year-old executive assistant whose only listed credential for the post was managing Trump's SEE TRUMP ON A10

Drones seen over base where Rubio, Hegseth live

BY ISAAC ARNSDORF
AND TARA COPP

U.S. officials detected unidentified drones above the Washington Army base where Secretary of State Marco Rubio and Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth live, according to three people briefed on the situation. Officials have not determined where they came from, two of the people said.

The military is monitoring potential threats more closely because of the heightened alert level as the United States and Israel strike Iran, according to a senior administration official who spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss sensitive security matters. Multiple drones were spotted over Fort Lesley J. McNair on a single night in the last 10 days, the official said, prompting increased security measures and a meeting at the White House to discuss how to respond.

The drone sightings in Washington come as the U.S. issued a SEE DRONE ON A4

IN THE NEWS

Mullin narrowly through A Senate committee voted 8-7 to send the nomination of Sen. Markwayne Mullin (R-Oklahoma) to lead DHS to the full Senate for consideration. **A6**

Patients intentionally misdiagnosed Nursing homes falsely label patients schizophrenic to sedate them, a watchdog group says. **A3**

THE NATION
Republicans are ramping up attacks on Muslims — and they are getting rewarded. **A3**
Voice of America employees hope to make up for lost time after their huge legal victory. **A6**

THE WORLD
A Pakistani strike kills hundreds, Afghanistan says, as conflict between the neighbors boils. **A13**

THE ECONOMY
Higher gas prices could start squeezing oil companies, too. **A18**

STYLE
Elijah Wood, the actor who lately has focused on under-the-radar indie movies, stars in the new horror-comedy “Ready or Not 2.” **B1**
Afroman prevails in a trial over songs about a police raid on his home that explored issues of free speech. **B1**

SPORTS
March Madness delivers a handful of upsets, including VCU knocking off No. 6 seed North Carolina in overtime. **B7**

THE REGION
Keith Pettigrew, head of D.C.'s Housing Authority, heads to Chicago in a move that surprised city leaders. **B13**

The iconic drum circles at the District's Malcolm X Park are going silent as long-overdue repairs are ready to begin. **B13**

WEEKEND
Cherry blossoms, D.C.'s favorite spring attraction, are again ready to make a dazzling display for all to enjoy.

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